

84 Elisha

Elijah's successor, a prophet of practical mercy who saw the unseen armies of God.

Elisha was a farmer's son ploughing a field when Elijah threw a prophet's mantle over him. He left home, served Elijah, and asked for a double portion of his spirit. For more than fifty years he was God's prophet in the northern kingdom, through the reigns of several kings. Where Elijah's ministry was marked by fire and confrontation, Elisha's was often marked by help for ordinary people. He purified a spring, filled a widow's jars with oil, raised a boy to life, fed a crowd, healed a Syrian general, and made an iron axe head float. He also anointed kings and advised armies. Even after his death, a dead man who touched his bones came back to life.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Elisha</i> , "God is salvation" or "my God saves"
Family	Son of Shaphat, of Abel-meholah (1 Kings 19:16)
When	Called under Ahab; prophet c. 850–795 BC, until the reign of Joash (Jehoash) of Israel
Key places	Abel-meholah, Jericho, Bethel, Shunem, Samaria, Dothan, Damascus
Key people	Elijah, Gehazi, the Shunammite woman, Naaman, Hazael, Jehu, Jehoshaphat
Death	Of an illness, in the reign of Joash king of Israel (2 Kings 13:14, 20)
New Testament	Called Eliseus; named once by Jesus (Luke 4:27)

"And he answered, Fear not: for they that be with us are more than they that be with them."

2 Kings 6:16, KJV

The life of Elisha

Dates are approximate (BC). The stories of 2 Kings 4–8 are undated and may not be in time order.

- c. 850s BC

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Called from the plough

Elijah throws his mantle over him. Elisha kills his oxen, feeds the people, and follows Elijah. *1 Kings 19:16, 19–21*
- c. 850 BC

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Receives the mantle

He asks for a double portion of Elijah's spirit, sees him taken up, and parts the Jordan with his mantle. *2 Kings 2:1–15*
- Early ministry

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Jericho and Bethel

He heals Jericho's spring with salt. Youths mock him near Bethel, and two bears maul forty-two of them. *2 Kings 2:19–25*
- Probably under Joram

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Mercy and healing

He multiplies a widow's oil, raises the Shunammite's son, and heals the Syrian general Naaman. *2 Kings 4:1–5:27*
- Syrian wars

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Dothan and Samaria

At Dothan his servant sees chariots of fire. In Samaria's terrible siege he promises food by the next day. *2 Kings 6:8–7:20*
- c. 842–841 BC

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Hazael and Jehu

He weeps as he tells Hazael he will be king, then sends a young prophet to anoint Jehu. *2 Kings 8:7–15; 9:1–10*
- c. 795 BC

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Death and burial

After his burial, a dead man thrown into his tomb touches his bones and revives. *2 Kings 13:14–21*

Group notes

Key activities

Scholars debate whether "little children" in 2 Kings 2:23 were children or young men, since the Hebrew words can cover both. The account itself is brief and hard, and readers differ on how to understand it.

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- I Left everything to follow.** He burned his ploughing equipment, cooked the oxen, and went after Elijah. *1 Kings 19:19-21*

 - 2 Asked for a double portion.** When Elijah offered him a request, he said, "let a double portion of thy spirit be upon me." *2 Kings 2:9-10*

 - 3 Took up the mantle.** He struck the Jordan and asked, "Where is the LORD God of Elijah?" The waters parted. *2 Kings 2:13-14*

 - 4 Healed bad water.** He threw salt into Jericho's spring, and the water became wholesome. *2 Kings 2:19-22*

 - 5 Filled a widow's jars.** A prophet's widow faced losing her sons to a creditor. Her little oil filled every jar she could borrow. *2 Kings 4:1-7*

 - 6 Raised a dead boy.** He prayed and stretched himself on the Shunammite's son, and the child sneezed seven times and opened his eyes. *2 Kings 4:32-37*

 - 7 Fed a hungry crowd.** He had twenty barley loaves set before a hundred men, and they ate and had some left. *2 Kings 4:42-44*

 - 8 Refused payment.** He would take no gift from Naaman, and he confronted Gehazi for secretly taking one. *2 Kings 5:15-27*

 - 9 Made iron float.** When a borrowed axe head fell into the Jordan, he threw in a stick and the iron swam. *2 Kings 6:1-7*

 - 10 Opened his servant's eyes.** He prayed, "LORD, I pray thee, open his eyes, that he may see," and the mountain was full of chariots of fire. *2 Kings 6:15-17*

 - II Fed his enemies.** He led blinded Syrian raiders into Samaria, then told the king to feed them and send them home. *2 Kings 6:18-23*

 - 12 Wept over Israel's future.** He fixed his gaze on Hazael and wept, knowing the evil Hazael would do. *2 Kings 8:11-13*

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Elisha.

Old Testament

1 Kings 19:16–21; 2 Kings 2–13	The main accounts of his life
1 Kings 19:16	Anointed "to be prophet in thy room"
2 Kings 8:4–5	"All the great things that Elisha hath done"
2 Kings 13:14	Joash: "O my father, my father, the chariot of Israel"
Echo: Joshua 3:14–17	Like Joshua, he crosses the Jordan to succeed

New Testament

Luke 4:27	None cleansed "saving Naaman the Syrian"
Echo: John 6:9–13	Jesus feeds thousands with barley loaves
Echo: Romans 12:20	"If thine enemy hunger, feed him"

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Elisha's servant see before and after Elisha prayed (2 Kings 6:15–17)?
2. *Understand:* Many of Elisha's miracles meet everyday needs: a debt, a pot of stew, a borrowed axe. What does that suggest about God?
3. *Apply:* Elisha left his oxen and his family's farm to follow God's call. What might God be asking you to leave behind, or to take up?
4. *Apply:* Elisha fed the soldiers who came to capture him. Who is one person you could treat with unexpected kindness this week?